

Mandelbrot, it was different: it was as if we both originated from the same country, meeting after years of frustrating exile, and were finally able to speak in our mother tongue without straining. He is the only flesh-and-bones teacher I ever had—my teachers are usually books in my library. I had way too little respect for mathematicians dealing with uncertainty and statistics to consider any of them my teachers—in my mind mathematicians, trained for certainties, had no business dealing with randomness. Mandelbrot proved me wrong.

He speaks an unusually precise and formal French, much like that spoken by Levantines of my parents' generation or Old World aristocrats. This made it odd to hear, on occasion, his accented, but very standard, colloquial American English. He is tall, overweight, which makes him look baby-faced (although I've never seen him eat a large meal), and has a strong physical presence.

From the outside one would think that what Mandelbrot and I have in common is wild uncertainty, Black Swans, and dull (and sometimes less dull) statistical notions. But, although we are collaborators, this is not what our major conversations revolve around. It is mostly matters literary and aesthetic, or historical gossip about people of extraordinary intellectual refinement. I mean refinement, not achievement. Mandelbrot could tell stories about the phenomenal array of hotshots he has worked with over the past century, but somehow I am programmed to consider scientists' personae far less interesting than those of colorful erudites. Like me, Mandelbrot takes an interest in urbane individuals who combine traits generally thought not to coexist together. One person he often mentions is Baron Pierre Jean de Menasce, whom he met at Princeton in the 1950s, where de Menasce was the roommate of the physicist Oppenheimer. De Menasce was exactly the kind of person I am interested in, the embodiment of a Black Swan. He came from an opulent Alexandrian Jewish merchant family, French and Italian-speaking like all sophisticated Levantines. His forebears had taken a Venetian spelling for their Arabic name, added a Hungarian noble title along the way, and socialized with royalty. De Menasce not only converted to Christianity, but became a Dominican priest and a great scholar of Semitic and Persian languages. Mandelbrot kept questioning me about Alexandria, since he was always looking for such characters.

True, intellectually sophisticated characters were exactly what I looked for in life. My erudite and polymathic father—who, were he still alive, would have only been two weeks older than Benoît M.—liked the company of extremely cultured Jesuit priests. I remember these Jesuit visitors occupying my chair at the dining table. I recall that one had a medical degree and a PhD in physics, yet taught Aramaic to locals in Beirut's Institute of Eastern Languages. His previous assignment could have been teaching high school